

Helena Cross

ACT I / Before the murder

Your history with Sterling

You wrote a private legal memorandum concluding that the Star Bowl's acquisition was too risky to defend confidently. Sterling forced you to replace it with a softer opinion and planned to cite your name during the announcement.

What you are hiding

Both versions of the memo still exist. You kept the original instead of destroying it, which could expose you to professional embarrassment and Sterling to serious scrutiny. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Your objectives

- Learn whether Vivienne has obtained a copy of your original memo.
- Keep Marcus from publicly speculating about your legal advice.
- Find out who has been searching the Registrar's Office.

What you know about other guests

- Vivienne's restitution negotiations would be badly damaged if Sterling announced permanent ownership tonight.
- Margot has been under unusual pressure over how Sterling wants his gift expenses classified.
- Sterling asked you how quickly he could seek an injunction against Nadia's upcoming investigation.

ACT II / After Sterling dies

Follow your assigned branch. Keep it private. If you are the murderer, the innocent branch is a cover story you may claim.

IF INNOCENT

A torn corner of your legal pad was found in the salon from your 6:28 meeting with Sterling. From 6:40 to 6:49, the Registrar's secure printer and fax log show you reproducing and transmitting the harsher original legal memo you had been pressured to soften. The record clears your timing but exposes both versions.

IF MURDERER

At 6:46 you returned with the original memo and demanded Sterling change his announcement. When he refused, you poisoned his cordial. A torn corner from your pad remained beneath the decanter.

ACT III / Evidence update

Your sealed evidence pair contains Cards A and B. If you are INNOCENT, secretly submit Card A. If you are the MURDERER, secretly submit Card B. Put the unused card away.

FINAL STATEMENT / Read only if called

IF INNOCENT

I wrote the first memo saying the acquisition was indefensible, and I let Sterling pressure me into softening it. I kept the original because I knew I might need the truth later. The secure printer and fax log shows me transmitting that original throughout the poison window. That is what I was protecting.

IF MURDERER

Sterling wanted my signature to transform risk into legitimacy. I gave him a final chance to change the announcement. He laughed. I poisoned the cordial, tore the note from my pad, and left. Lawyers are trained to live with ambiguity. I decided I could not live with his.